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Culture (OWC): [Khoi \(FX13\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: No Date

**Place Coverage**

General Khoi; western South Africa and southern Namibia

**Section Title(S)**

KIN GROUPS AND DESCENT • KINSHIP • KINSHIP TERMINOLOGY • LAND TENURE

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## LAND TENURE

In precolonial times, several clan-based villages were united into much larger units called tribes or hordes, which ranged in size from a few hundred to several thousand individuals. The most significant aspect of tribal integrity related to the various clans' unrestricted access to communal tribal land. Local clans could move around and utilize pasture, water resources, game, and wild fruit and vegetables within the tribal area (although individual clans tended to move in a regular pattern in a specific tract of tribal land). The relatively low population density prior to the arrival of Europeans meant that there was limited competition for any given piece of land, and the extent of tribal land was thus defined not so much in terms of exact boundaries as with reference to land around key water holes as well as areas with better pasture.

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The communal character of land tenure has been retained in most of the contemporary reserves, and local populations have resisted government's attempts to create individual farms. Although specific plots of land are allocated to individual farmers in some of the reserves (where crop cultivation is possible), such plots are not privately owned and remain under the control of the local communities.

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## KINSHIP

### KIN GROUPS AND DESCENT

The exogamous patrilineal clan was the basic unit of social organization. Although tribal groupings were unstable and mobile, and were not composed exclusively of clan members, the Khoi kept detailed oral genealogies of the origins of various clans and of the relationship between them. This knowledge was very important, since precedence within tribes and clans was by primogeniture.

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During most of the twentieth century, descent has been used as an important indication of status—higher status being associated with “white” blood. More recently, the opposite trend has been emerging: people are keen to emphasize their Khoi history.

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## KINSHIP TERMINOLOGY

Individuals were given both patrilineal clan names and “great names”—names inherited by a group of brothers from their mother, or of sisters from their father. In this way, men shared their name with their maternal grandfather, and women with their maternal grandmother. These names were closely associated with the pattern of institutionalized joking and avoidance relationships between kin.

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